

GENERAL STUDIES

Name of Candidate		Program	Ascend 2024
UPSC Roll No.		Subject	
Mobile No.		Test Number	09
E-mail		Date	
Start Time:	End Time:	Mode of Exam	

Time Allowed: **3 Hours**

Maximum Marks: **250**

INDEX TABLE		
Q. No.	Maximum Marks	Marks Obtained
1.a	10	
1.b	10	
2.a	10	
2.b	10	
3.a	10	
3.b	10	
4.a	10	
4.b	10	
5.a	10	
5.b	10	
6.a	10	
6.b	10	
6.c	10	
7	20	
8	20	
9	20	
10	20	
11	20	
12	20	
Total: 250		
Marks awarded		

INSTRUCTIONS
1. Do furnish the appropriate details in the answer sheet (viz. Name, Email, Roll No, Mobile No). 2. There are 12 questions in this booklet, all questions are compulsory. 3. The number of marks carried by a question/part is indicated against it. 4. Question no. 1 to 6 should be answered in 150 words, whereas Question no. 7 to 12 should be answered in 250 words. Keep the words limit indicated in the questions in mind. 5. Any answer written outside the space allotted may not be given credit. 6. Any page or portion of the page left blank in the Question-Cum Answer booklet must be clearly Struck off.
INSTRUCTIONS FOR UPLOADING SCANNED COPY
1. Furnish all the entries on your answer sheet according to template. 2. After completion of the paper, scan and prepare PDF file of answer sheet in order of page number. 3. Check file size and clarity of scanned pages. 4. Ensure that you do not make PDF file of photos directly, use “brightening feature” or “auto colour feature” in App to enhance the image quality of PDF. 5. Not following the above instructions may lead to delayed or no evaluation.

Parameters	Excellent	Good	Average	Below Average
Attempts				
Content Quality				
Structure and Flow				
Presentation				
Language				

If you have any subject related or answer writing related query/doubt, then please write here:

Feedback

Section A

- Q1. (a)** True compassion means not only feeling another's pain but also being moved to help relieve it. Discuss.
(10 marks, 150 words)



- 1. (b)** Discuss how the conflict between the Right to Information (RTI) and the Right to Privacy (RTP) can be reconciled with public interest in mind.
(10 Marks, 150 Words)



- Q2. (a)** Discuss the ethical considerations that bureaucratic institutions must consider while using social influence tactics to achieve policy objectives. Provide examples to illustrate your points. (10 marks, 150 words)



- 2. (b)** Explain the concept of political neutrality and its significance in administration. Also, highlight how the Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules seek to ensure political neutrality in the civil services. (10 marks, 150 words)



Q3. (a) 'The essence of administrative morality lies in ethical decision-making.' In this context, discuss the challenges faced while making ethical decisions in public administration. (10 marks, 150 words)



- 3. (b)** “Climate change is a global challenge that demands a unified global response.” How can ethical principles shape international cooperation and collaboration to tackle this issue?
(10 marks, 150 words)



- Q4. (a)** The Modern Bureaucracy must embrace virtues of cooperation and uphold the highest moral values to effectively serve the public interest. Discuss.
(10 marks, 150 words)



- 4. (b)** Highlight the components of a Citizen's Charter. What ethical responsibilities does the government have to ensure adherence to the Citizen's Charter?
(10 marks, 150 words)



Q5. (a) What are the issues affecting the effective utilization of funds in India? Also, propose measures to overcome these issues. (10 Marks, 150 Words)





5. (b) What do you understand by ethics in private and public relationships? Do you believe public and private ethics influence each other, or are they mutually exclusive?

(10 Marks, 150 Words)





Q6.

What do the following quotations mean to you in the present context and context of public service.

- (a) "The greatest sin is to remain silent and inactive during times of moral crisis, when taking a stand is crucial." Srila prabhupada (10 marks, 150 words)



- 6. (b)** “Tolerance implies no lack of commitment to one’s own beliefs. Rather it condemns the oppression or persecution of others.”- John F. Kennedy. (10 marks, 150 words)





- 6. (c)** "We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence, then, is not an act, but a habit"-
Aristotle. (10 marks, 150 words)



Section B

- Q7.** You are serving as the Tourism Development Officer in the Department of Tourism of the Island State. The island archipelago is renowned for its pristine landscapes, vibrant coral reefs, and unique cultural heritage. Recently, the region has been experiencing a significant transformation due to a substantial increase in tourist arrivals, driven by improved accessibility and growing global interest in its unique attractions.

To leverage this opportunity, the Union Government has proposed developing the island as a premier beach tourism destination, taking advantage of its natural beauty and strategic location. A substantial budget of Rupees 2000 crore has been allocated for developing essential infrastructure, including hotels, villas, parks, gardens, and medical facilities. However, the indigenous population and local NGOs have raised concerns about the potential environmental impacts of the project, supported by expert opinions. This opposition has gained significant traction on social media with the hashtag #SavePlanet, increasing public pressure on the government to reconsider the project.

In light of these developments, a committee has been formed within the Tourism Department, with you as the head, to address the situation amicably.

- (a) Discuss the ethical dilemmas involved in the case above.
- (b) Analyse the roles of different stakeholders in balancing economic development with environmental conservation.
- (c) As the head of the committee, propose measures to develop a sustainable tourism model for the island that ensures equitable benefits for all stakeholders.

(20 marks, 250 words)







Q8.

In today's competitive academic environment, there is a troubling rise in suicide rates among young students. Academic excellence has become a top priority, with mounting pressure from societal expectations and the pervasive influence of social media. Students are under immense stress to meet high aspirations, navigating a landscape where success is often equated with academic achievements. The relentless pursuit of perfection, driven by both external pressures and personal ambitions, severely impacts their mental well-being.

Social media further aggravates the situation by providing a platform for constant comparison against curated lives, leading to unrealistic standards of success that often seem unattainable. These factors contribute to a growing epidemic of student suicides in India, a silent crisis that urgently needs to be addressed.

- (a) What preventive measures and intervention strategies can be implemented to address student suicides and promote their mental well-being?
- (b) What role does social media play in exacerbating the mental health crisis among students? Also, suggest measures to address the issue.

(20 marks, 250 words)









Q9.

You have been appointed as the Superintendent of Police (SP) in a district of a Northeastern state of India facing several challenges. One of the most pressing issues is illegal migration from a neighboring country, which has led to conflicts between local inhabitants and migrants over limited resources. Recently, violence broke out between migrants and indigenous communities in your district, resulting in the sexual harassment of women from the indigenous minority community. Disturbing videos of these incidents have been circulated on social media, escalating tensions and causing widespread violence throughout the district.

Amid the chaos, radical elements have exploited the situation to incite further unrest. There are concerns that the neighboring country may be supporting these elements with manpower and resources. The escalating violence has forced many residents to flee to safer nearby areas. The crisis has drawn international media attention, damaged the country's image and increased pressure to resolve the situation. The state government has issued urgent orders to bring the situation under control immediately.

- (a) Identify the various dimensions involved in the case given above.
 - (b) In such trying circumstances, which specific steps will you take to control the overall situation in the district?
 - (c) Suggest long-term measures which can be adopted to ensure peace and tranquility in the region.
- (20 marks, 250 words)









Q10.

Mrs. Sujata has recently been appointed as the Secretary of the Food, Civil Supply, and Consumer Affairs Department in a frontier state. Known for her efficient service delivery and no-nonsense approach, she immediately authorizes a performance audit of her department, including an evaluation of the state's ration card system, aiming to improve its overall functioning. The department has recently been in the news for negative reasons, prompting her swift action.

During the audit, Mrs. Sujata discovers widespread issues within the ration card system, including the existence of millions of bogus ration cards, lengthy waiting periods for genuine applicants, bribery, and arbitrary cancellations of cards. She also notes a lack of enthusiasm within the department towards digitization, with visible resistance to adopting technology to streamline processes.

The internal audit reveals that these issues are causing substantial financial losses to the exchequer, estimated at nearly ₹1500 crore annually, due to approximately 2 crore fake ration cards in circulation. Meanwhile, genuine beneficiaries are being excluded from receiving the intended benefits.

Mrs. Sujata raises the issue with the concerned minister, emphasizing the urgent need for reform. However, she is surprised by the minister's disinterest, as he cites the upcoming elections and argues that many of these ration cards are remnants from the previous government, distributed without oversight, and are now seen as politically necessary for the current administration.

Not convinced by this explanation, Mrs. Sujata has come across reports suggesting that food grains meant for the public distribution system have been diverted through various means, with allegations that the minister may be benefiting from these activities.

(a) Considering the scenario, formulate a detailed strategy outlining the steps Sujata can take to reform the dysfunctional ration card system.

(b) Suggest how Sujata can overcome resistance from the officials, enhance accountability, and rebuild public trust in the system. (20 marks, 250 words)







Q11. You are the CEO of a startup that has recently been underperforming, leading to mounting pressure from investors to increase revenue and maintain profitability. One day, your Finance Officer, Akash, confesses to you that he misappropriated Rs. 1,00,000 from the company a few months ago. Upon further inquiry, Akash explains that he was under extreme financial distress at the time due to his wife's life-threatening illness. You recall him mentioning this issue to you previously, but it slipped your mind due to heavy work pressure.

Akash reveals that his conscience has been troubling him, prompting him to confess. You know that Akash has been a competent, technically skilled, and loyal employee with no history of negative behavior. Given the circumstances, you feel compelled to let him go but do not wish to ruin his career. As a compromise, you decide not to fire him but ask for his resignation instead.

A few weeks after Akash leaves, you receive a call from your friend Vivek, the Human Resources Manager of another company and your batchmate from IIM Kolkata. Akash has applied for a finance job at Vivek's company, and Vivek calls you to ask for your professional and personal opinion of Akash.

- (a) Identify the ethical dilemmas you face in this situation.
- (b) Critically evaluate the different options available to you.
- (c) What would you recommend to Vivek, and why?

(20 marks, 250 words)







Q12.

Rajesh is a Public Information Officer (PIO) in a government department, responsible for handling Right to Information (RTI) applications. Over the years, he has reflected on the challenges associated with implementing the RTI Act. Although the RTI Act has significantly empowered citizens and redefined accountability in Indian democracy, Rajesh has noticed some concerning trends.

Some individuals are filing RTI applications on behalf of stakeholders with vested interests, often seeking information that benefits specific groups rather than serving the larger public good. Rajesh finds that handling these requests consumes a significant amount of his time and resources, diverting attention from genuinely important public issues.

He has also encountered RTI activists who use the Act for personal gain rather than the pursuit of justice. These individuals often attempt to extort money from decision-makers, threatening to expose alleged wrongdoings if their demands are not met. Such unethical practices have not only hindered administrative functioning but also cast doubt on the legitimacy of applications filed by honest citizens.

Rajesh has also observed that the fear of public scrutiny has made many of his colleagues' risk-averse, reluctant to make prompt decisions. While the RTI Act was intended to promote transparency, it has unintentionally created an atmosphere of caution and delay.

Recently, Rajesh faced an ethical dilemma when an RTI application was filed by a rival political party seeking sensitive information about an ongoing project. He suspected that the information might be used to gain political advantage and disrupt the project's progress, putting him in a difficult position between fulfilling his duty to provide information and preventing potential misuse for political gains.

Additionally, Rajesh struggles with balancing the right to information with data privacy, as some RTI applications request information that could compromise national security or individual privacy.

As he sits at his desk surrounded by RTI applications, Rajesh feels frustration and uncertainty. He knows that the RTI Act is a powerful tool for good governance, but he also recognizes the challenges that have emerged in its implementation.

(a) What moral values and ethical principles should Rajesh, as a PIO, uphold to ensure the RTI Act remains an effective tool for ethical governance?

(b) How can Rajesh and his department distinguish between genuine and frivolous RTI applications?

(c) What measures can the department take to encourage prompt decision-making while maintaining transparency and accountability?

(20 marks, 250 words)







